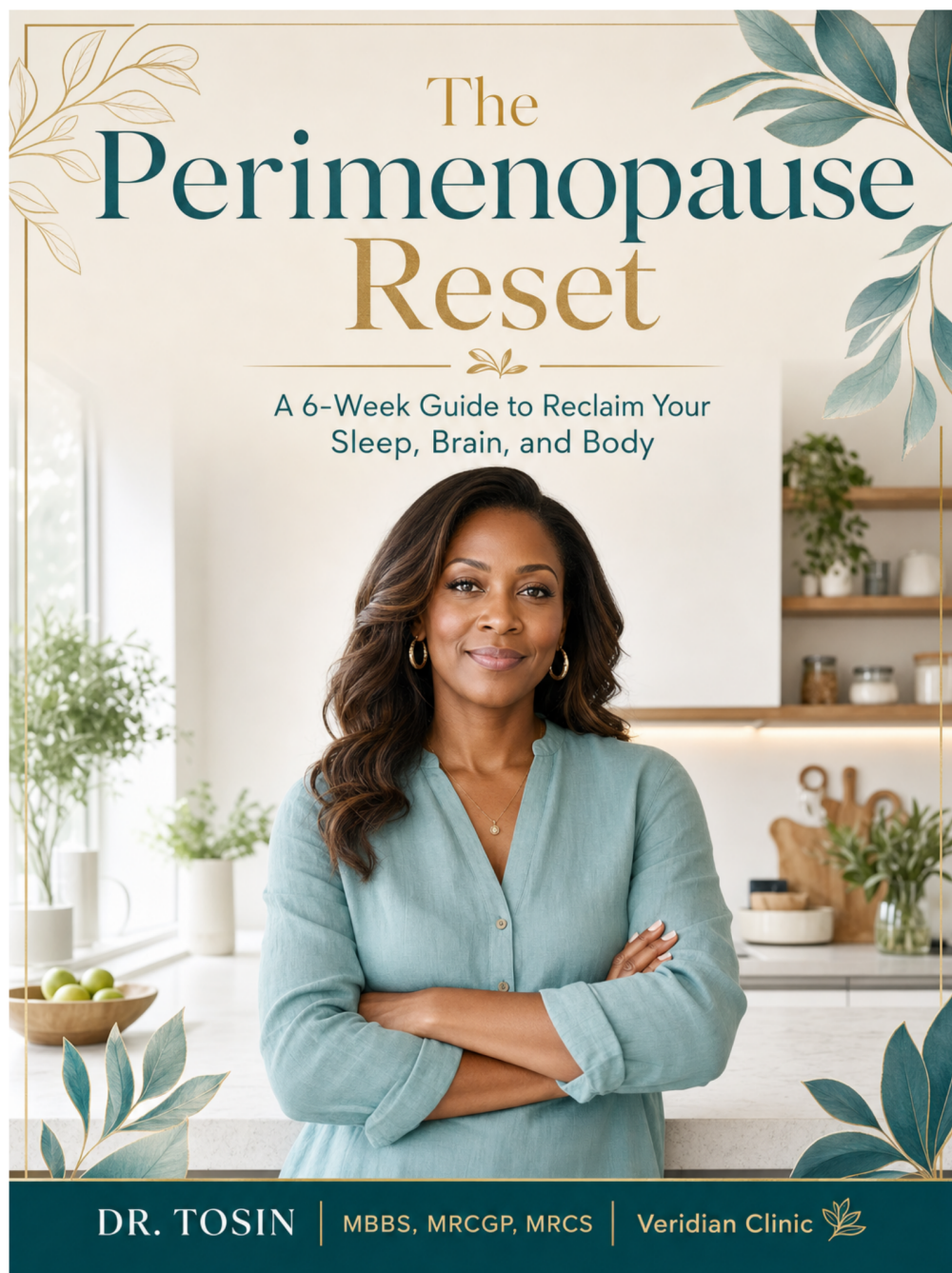


The Perimenopause Reset: A 6-Week Guide to Reclaim Your Sleep, Brain, and Body



About the Author

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In his work at Veridian Clinic, he combines evidence-based medicine with practical, step-by-step lifestyle plans. His passion is finding hidden drivers of symptoms and giving women clear, realistic frameworks they can follow, even with busy lives and multiple responsibilities.

Medical Disclaimer

- This guide is for information and education; it is not personalised medical advice and does not create a doctor–patient relationship.
- It is **not** suitable for pregnant or breastfeeding women, or anyone under 18.
- Women with conditions such as diabetes, heart disease, kidney or liver disease, thyroid disorders, eating disorders, significant mental-health conditions, or on regular medication must speak with their own clinician before making major changes.
- Blood tests and private services mentioned are optional.
- UK and international guidelines often diagnose perimenopause based on symptoms alone in women over 45; hormone blood tests are not always required, but can be helpful to rule out other issues and to assess overall health. [1] [2]

Know Your Numbers Before You Reset

Before you start, Dr Tosin recommends a baseline hormone and health panel. This helps rule out conditions that mimic perimenopause and guides your plan.

→ [**Book your Virtual Clinic Hormone & Health Panel here**](#)

Not Sure Where to Start?

If you are unsure whether this guide is right for you, or you want a GP to review your symptoms and blood tests, you can book a **discounted discovery call** with Dr Tosin.

→ [**Book your discounted midlife health discovery call here**](#)

How to Use This Guide

You **do not have to read everything at once**. This guide is designed to be simple to follow, not overwhelming.

1. **Know Your Numbers:** Read the lab section and book your blood tests first.
2. **Understand the Transition:** Read the "Understanding Perimenopause" section.
3. **The PERC Framework:** Skim the overview to understand our core pillars.
4. **Choose Your Goal:** Focus on sleep, brain fog, weight, or mood.
5. **Start the Reset:** Begin with Week 1 and use the daily checklists.

Step 1: Know Your Numbers Before You Reset

Before you change how you eat, move, fast, or sleep, it is wise to understand where your health is starting from. Baseline blood tests help to rule out other conditions that look like perimenopause (for example, thyroid disease or iron deficiency) and map your cardiometabolic risk. [3] [4] [5]

Sample Example of Comprehensive Hormone & Health Panel

The table below shows an example of what a comprehensive hormonal and health blood panel might look like. This is a sample illustration only. Your actual results will vary and must be interpreted by a qualified clinician in the context of your symptoms and medical history.

If you have not yet had your baseline blood work done, we strongly recommend doing so before making significant lifestyle changes.

→ [Click here to request your private hormone and health blood panel](#)

Test	What it checks
Estradiol (E2)	The primary female sex hormone, which fluctuates wildly before declining
Progesterone	The calming hormone that often drops first, affecting sleep and anxiety
FSH (Follicle-Stimulating Hormone)	Ovarian function and menopausal stage
LH (Luteinizing Hormone)	Ovarian function and menopausal stage
Testosterone (Total & Free)	Crucial for women's energy, libido, and muscle mass maintenance
DHEA-S (DHEA Sulphate)	An adrenal precursor that can influence energy, mood, libido, and sex-steroid production. Levels fall with age. Requires careful interpretation — not "good or bad" on its own.
Pregnenolone	A precursor hormone that is the starting point for the production of many other hormones. Supplementation is not recommended without direct medical supervision.

Test	What it checks
Thyroid Function (TSH, fT4, fT3)	Thyroid hormone levels, crucial for metabolism and energy
Full Blood Count (FBC)	General health, anaemia, and inflammation markers
Fasting Glucose & HbA1c	Blood sugar regulation and insulin resistance risk
Vitamin D	Bone health, mood, and immune function
Ferritin (Iron Stores)	Energy, fatigue, and hair health

Part 1 – Understanding Perimenopause & Why You Feel This Way

Why This Guide Exists

Many women are under-served by standard care and feel dismissed or told it is "just stress". You may have visited your GP multiple times, been told your blood tests are "normal", and left feeling unheard. This guide exists because you deserve a structured, evidence-aware blueprint — not a vague suggestion to "reduce stress".

This guide is based on:

- A **high-protein, whole-food, low-junk** approach.
- **Gentle time-restricted eating** (12–14 hours overnight), not extreme fasting.
- **Daily circadian reset**: sunlight exposure and simple nervous-system tools.
- **Grounding** as a practical way to down-shift stress and adrenaline.
- Targeted **blood work**, including DHEA and pregnenolone, to understand adrenal and sex-hormone precursors.

HOW PERIMENOPAUSE AFFECTS YOUR BODY



The Struggle in Your 40s: Brain Fog, Broken Sleep, and Stubborn Weight Gain

Many women in their 40s find themselves suddenly struggling with **brain fog**, **broken sleep**, and **stubborn weight gain**. These symptoms are driven by the fluctuating and declining levels of two key hormones: **oestrogen** and **progesterone**.

During perimenopause, both hormones become unpredictable. Oestrogen surges and drops erratically, disrupting the brain's energy metabolism, neurotransmitter function, and temperature regulation — which is why brain fog, hot flushes, and mood changes occur. Progesterone, which has a calming, sleep-promoting effect, also declines and becomes irregular, which is why anxiety spikes and deep, restorative sleep becomes harder to achieve.

It is the interaction between these two hormones — not just oestrogen alone — that creates the "zone of hormonal chaos" many women describe. [15] [16] [17] [18] [19] [20]

Why You Feel Wired, Hot and Angry

During perimenopause, the brain's "thermostat" narrows. Small changes in core temperature can trigger a big sympathetic surge. Hot flushes are not just "oestrogen falling" – they often come with a spike in **adrenaline and other stress hormones**, which explains the pounding heart, sweating, sudden heat, and urge to escape.

Chronic stress, poor sleep, caffeine, alcohol and blood-sugar crashes all raise baseline adrenaline and make these spikes more frequent. Many women describe sudden "rage episodes" — a flash of intense anger that feels completely out of proportion. This is often driven by the same catecholamine surge.

The programme uses:

- High-protein, low-junk meals to stabilise blood sugar.
- Morning light and grounding to reset the stress axis.
- Reduced caffeine and alcohol to lower sympathetic over-activity.
- Strength training with adequate recovery to harden the system without burning it out.

Part 2 – The PERC Framework for Your Reset

Every single day of this guide will touch all four PERC pillars, even if only briefly. The daily checklists at the end of each week make this concrete and actionable.

Pillar	What it means	Primary focus weeks
Prepare	Set your environment, mindset, and health baseline	Week 1
Eat & Eliminate	Shift your plate towards high-protein, whole-food, low-junk eating	Weeks 2–3
Reset	Use gentle time-restricted eating (TRE) to steady hormones and sleep	Weeks 3–4
Condition	Strengthen your body and nervous system with resistance training and walking	Weeks 4–6

The 10-Minute Morning Reset

This is a **non-negotiable practice across all six weeks**. It appears in every weekly checklist because it is the single most powerful free tool you have for managing perimenopausal symptoms.



Step 1: Go outside within 30 minutes of waking (balcony, garden, street).

Step 2: Spend 10–15 minutes in natural light, without sunglasses if safe.

Step 3: During that time, either:

- Walk gently, or
- Stand barefoot on grass/earth (grounding) if available and comfortable, and
- Breathe slowly (e.g. 4–6 calm breaths per minute).

Why This Matters

- **Morning light** helps set your circadian rhythm, telling your brain it is daytime now and preparing melatonin for the evening. Melatonin is produced in the morning through sunlight exposure, but released at night.

- **Grounding and slow breathing** help reduce adrenaline and cortisol spikes, which drive hot flushes, palpitations, anxiety and "ragey" episodes.
- Seeing the **sunset** also helps signal your brain that the day is ending, further supporting your sleep-wake cycle.

Part 3 – The 6-Week Reset Plan

This section gives you a clear, week-by-week plan with concrete actions, obstacles, and "if you fall off, do this" resets. Keep the three phases in mind, but follow the weeks one at a time.

Week 1 – Baseline Stabiliser

What this week is about: Week 1 is not about radical change. It is about removing friction, taking stock of where you are, and making a few simple swaps that will create the foundation for everything that follows. Many women try to change everything at once in Week 1 and then burn out by Week 2. Do not do that. Small, consistent actions compound.

This week, you will:

- Introduce the **10-Minute Morning Reset** (sunlight + optional grounding + slow breathing).
- Clean up the kitchen (remove seed oils, sugary drinks, obvious junk).
- Introduce ONE protein-plus-veg meal daily.
- Set a fixed wake-up time.
- Organise blood tests.

Daily Actions

- **Monday:** Clear your kitchen of sugary drinks, sweets, ultra-processed snacks, and industrial seed oils (rapeseed, sunflower, "vegetable oil"). Do not replace them yet — just remove them.
- **Tuesday:** Build your first "Reset Plate" at dinner: protein + non-starchy vegetables + a small portion of healthy fat (olive oil, butter, or avocado).
- **Wednesday:** Set your wake-up time and set an alarm. Non-negotiable — even if you went to bed late.
- **Thursday:** Take a 15-minute walk after your main meal. This is your first "movement medicine" session.
- **Friday:** Review your symptoms using the self-check list in Part 1. Note which 2–3 symptoms are most disruptive.
- **Saturday:** Book your blood tests if you have not done so.
- **Sunday:** Rest, reflect, and prepare your shopping list for Week 2.

What to eat this week

- Focus on adding, not restricting. Add a protein source to every meal (eggs, chicken, fish, Greek yoghurt, cottage cheese).
- Drink water or herbal tea instead of sugary drinks.
- Reduce obvious sugar (sweets, biscuits, fizzy drinks) by 50%.

- Do not start fasting this week. Allow your body to adjust to the food quality changes first.

Sleep focus this week

- Set one fixed wake-up time and keep it every day.
- **Circadian Rhythm Reset:** Get outside to see natural morning sunlight within 30 minutes of waking.
- Switch off screens 30 minutes before bed.
- Keep your bedroom cooler than you think you need — 16–18°C is ideal.

Daily PERC Checklist — Week 1

PERC Pillar	Today's Focus	Done?
Prepare	Fixed wake-up time. 10-Minute Morning Reset.	☐
Eat & Eliminate	One protein+veg meal. Remove obvious junk and seed oils.	☐
Reset	Leave 2–3 hours between last meal and bed.	☐
Condition	10–20 minute walk.	☐

If You Are Struggling This Week...

What if I miss a day or a meal?

Do not panic. Simply return to the plan for your next meal or the next morning. One missed day does not undo your progress.

What if I had a chaotic week and did nothing?

Restart from Monday in 3 steps: (1) fixed wake time, (2) 10-Minute Morning Reset, (3) one protein meal. That is your bare minimum day.

What if I have a massive hot flush day?

Focus only on the 10-Minute Morning Reset. Grounding and slow breathing will help lower adrenaline. Avoid caffeine and alcohol today.

What if my anxiety spikes and I feel like quitting?

This is normal during hormonal fluctuations. Focus only on the Morning Reset and a short walk. Do not add anything else today.

When should I pause and speak to my GP?

If you experience severe symptoms, extreme dizziness, chest pain, unmanageable anxiety, or thoughts of self-harm, pause the programme and book a GP review immediately.

Reminder: If symptoms remain severe after Week 1, consider booking a discovery call with Dr Tosin to review your situation.

→ [Book your discounted discovery call here](#)

Week 2 – Protein & Plate Week

What this week is about: This week focuses on building your nutritional engine. You will learn to build high-protein meals using familiar, culturally appropriate foods that stabilise blood sugar and reduce adrenaline spikes. Protein is not optional in perimenopause — it is the single most important macronutrient for preserving muscle, managing hunger, and supporting hormone production.

This week, you will:

- Aim for 20–25g protein at 2–3 meals daily.
- Use the **UK multicultural plate grid** to build familiar meals (African/Caribbean, South Asian, Western, etc.).
- Keep the 10-Minute Morning Reset and fixed wake time.
- Cook with whole-food fats only (olive oil, coconut oil, butter, ghee). No seed oils.

Daily PERC Checklist — Week 2

PERC Pillar	Today's Focus	Done?
Prepare	10-Minute Morning Reset. Plan meals for the day.	☐
Eat & Eliminate	20–25g protein at 2–3 meals. No seed oils.	☐
Reset	Maintain fixed wake time.	☐
Condition	20-minute walk or one bodyweight session.	☐

If You Are Struggling This Week...

I feel too full on high-protein meals – what do I do?

Start with smaller portions of protein and gradually increase. Ensure you are chewing well and eating slowly. Your body will adapt within a few days.

I'm bored of chicken – what are my other options in my cultural kitchen?

Try wild-caught sardines, mackerel, eggs, lean beef, lamb, prawns, cottage cheese, Greek yoghurt, lentils, chickpeas, or tofu. See the multicultural grid in Part 4.

I cannot manage the fasting window.

You are not fasting yet — that starts in Week 3. This week, focus only on protein quality and quantity.

Missed meal / binge episode?

Bare minimum day = protein breakfast, 10-minute Morning Reset, 10–20 minute walk, fixed wake time. Resume normal eating at the next meal.

Week 3 – Metabolic & Sleep Engine

What this week is about: You are now adding the structures that will drive real change in sleep quality, blood sugar stability, body composition, and mental clarity. This is where most women start to notice the first improvements — less brain fog in the morning, slightly less disruptive night waking, and more consistent energy across the day.

This week, you will:

- Start 12–14 hour overnight time-restricted eating (TRE).
- Implement a caffeine cut-off at 2 pm.
- Remove alcohol for at least 7 days.
- Start an evening wind-down routine (no screens last 30 minutes).
- Keep the 10-Minute Morning Reset.

Important: If you are diabetic or take medication that affects blood sugar, do not start TRE without first speaking to your own doctor. TRE means compressing all your eating into a set daily window and fasting the rest of the time. Start with a 12-hour window (for example, 7pm to 7am). If that feels manageable after 3–4 days, extend to 14 hours. Do not go beyond 14 hours without medical supervision.

Daily PERC Checklist — Week 3

PERC Pillar	Today's Focus	Done?
Prepare	10-Minute Morning Reset. Plan eating window.	☐
Eat & Eliminate	No caffeine after 2pm. No alcohol. Protein at every meal.	☐
Reset	12–14 hour overnight fast. Wind-down routine.	☐
Condition	20-minute walk (after dinner if possible).	☐

If You Are Struggling This Week...

What if TRE makes me dizzy or anxious?

Shorten the window back to 12 hours. Make sure breakfast is protein-rich, not just coffee. Do not force TRE if it worsens symptoms.

What if I wake at 3 am drenched in sweat?

This is extremely common in perimenopause and is often driven by a progesterone dip. Do not lie in bed staring at the ceiling. Get up, go to a different room, do something quiet for 10–15 minutes in dim light, then return to bed. Do not look at your phone.

What if I cannot manage the fasting window?

Start with simply not eating after 8pm. Even a 12-hour window is beneficial. Do not push yourself into discomfort — this should feel manageable, not punishing.

Huge flush or panic-day?

Bare minimum day = protein breakfast, 10-minute Morning Reset, 10–20 minute walk, fixed wake time. Skip the TRE today if needed.

Week 4 – Strength & Sympathetic Downshift

What this week is about: This week introduces structured resistance training to build muscle, protect bones, and buffer adrenaline spikes. You will also add a dedicated daily down-shifting practice to teach your nervous system how to switch from "fight or flight" to "rest and digest".



This week, you will:

- Complete 2–3 strength sessions (progressive overload).
- Continue the daily 10-Minute Morning Reset.
- Add a daily 5–10 minute down-shifting practice (breathwork, stretching, or grounding).
- Maintain TRE and protein goals from previous weeks.

How strength training buffers adrenaline spikes

Resistance training teaches your body to handle physical stress in a controlled way. Over time, this raises your threshold for sympathetic activation — meaning you are less likely to be tipped into a flush,

palpitation, or rage episode by minor stressors. It also improves insulin sensitivity, protects bone density, and preserves the muscle mass that naturally declines from your 40s onwards.

Daily PERC Checklist — Week 4

PERC Pillar	Today's Focus	Done?
Prepare	10-Minute Morning Reset.	☐
Eat & Eliminate	Maintain protein goals. No seed oils.	☐
Reset	5–10 min down-shifting practice (breathwork/grounding).	☐
Condition	Strength session or 20-min walk.	☐

If You Are Struggling This Week...

I don't have time for 3 gym sessions a week.

Two sessions is fine. Even 20 minutes of bodyweight work at home counts. Squats, lunges, press-ups, and glute bridges — no gym required.

Unable to exercise that week?

Bare minimum day = protein breakfast, 10-minute Morning Reset, 10–20 minute walk, fixed wake time. Resume strength training next week.

I feel exhausted after training.

You may be doing too much too soon. Reduce intensity, ensure you are eating enough protein, and prioritise sleep. Recovery is where the gains happen.

Week 5 – Consolidation & Cultural Tailoring

What this week is about: This phase is about consolidation, not perfection. You have built the engine; now you are learning how to drive it long-term. The goal is to keep what is working, gently refine your meals using culturally familiar foods, and build resilience so that when life gets busy, you don't lose your progress.

This week, you will:

- Maintain core patterns; refine meals using the cultural grid.
- Design 3–4 "default meals" you can fall back on when tired or stressed.
- Optional: repeat bloods if you had an initial panel and 3–6 months have passed.
- Continue strength training (2–3 sessions) and daily Morning Reset.

Daily PERC Checklist — Week 5

PERC Pillar	Today's Focus	Done?
Prepare	10-Minute Morning Reset. Use a "default meal" if busy.	☐
Eat & Eliminate	Maintain protein goals. Refine with cultural grid.	☐
Reset	Maintain TRE window.	☐
Condition	Strength session or walk. Push slightly harder.	☐

If You Are Struggling This Week...

How do I adjust this plan during Ramadan / busy festivals / family events?
Focus on protein first at every meal you do eat. Enjoy the event. Return to your default meals the next day. One day off-plan does not undo weeks of progress.

What if family members won't eat what I eat?

Build modular meals. Cook a core protein and veg base, then add different carbohydrate sides for family members who want them. You do not need to cook separately — just plate differently.

I feel like I've plateaued.

This is normal. Progress is not always linear. Check your sleep, stress levels, and protein intake. Consider repeating your blood tests to see objective changes.

Week 6 – Review, Labs & Next Pathway

What this week is about: This is your review week. You will measure your progress, celebrate your wins, and decide on your next steps for long-term maintenance.

This week, you will:

- Measure change (waist circumference, sleep scale, brain fog, energy).
- Decide whether to:
 - Repeat Weeks 1–2 as a mini-reset,
 - Run another full 6-week cycle, or
 - Move to maintenance (80% adherence).
- Continue all core habits (Morning Reset, protein, TRE, strength).

Daily PERC Checklist — Week 6

PERC Pillar	Today's Focus	Done?
Prepare	Review progress. Measure waist, sleep, energy.	☐
Eat & Eliminate	Maintain protein goals.	☐
Reset	Maintain TRE window.	☐
Condition	Strength session or walk.	☐

If You Are Struggling This Week...

When your symptoms are severe or not improving:

It is time to book a GP review. Do not push through severe symptoms. This guide is a foundation, not a replacement for medical care when it is needed.

Ready for the next step? If you want personalised guidance, a review of your blood results, or help deciding whether HRT is right for you, book a consultation with Dr Tosin.

→ **[Book your discounted discovery call here](#)**

Part 4 – Food: Plates, Shopping Lists, and Simple Meals

Diet Philosophy

Fats: What to Use and What to Avoid

Category	Foods
Use for cooking	Coconut oil, ghee, butter, tallow
Use for finishing / dressings	Extra-virgin olive oil, avocado oil
Avoid completely	Rapeseed/canola oil, sunflower oil, soybean oil, corn oil, cottonseed oil, generic "vegetable oil"

Industrial seed oils are pro-inflammatory, omega-6-heavy oils that can worsen low-grade inflammation and joint pain in midlife. They are found in most processed foods, takeaways, and restaurant cooking. When you cook at home with whole-food fats, you take back control of what enters your body.

Soy

Large amounts of processed soy are not recommended in this programme. Small, traditional, fermented soy (e.g. miso, tempeh) may be consumed occasionally. The plan emphasises non-soy proteins: eggs, fish, meat, dairy, pulses, nuts, and seeds.

Progesterone-Supportive Foods

While food cannot replace hormones, some nutrients may help support the systems that make and metabolise progesterone:

- **B-vitamin-rich foods** (especially B6): poultry, fish, eggs, chickpeas, bananas, pumpkin.
- **Magnesium-rich foods**: leafy greens, nuts, seeds, dark chocolate.
- **Healthy fats**: olive oil, avocado, oily fish, nuts and seeds – raw materials for hormone synthesis.

- **Cruciferous vegetables:** broccoli, cabbage, cauliflower, kale – may support healthy oestrogen metabolism, which in turn helps rebalance oestrogen/progesterone dynamics.

The Metabolic Reset Plate



- **Protein (1/4 of your plate):** Aim for 20–25g per meal. Wild-caught sardines, salmon, beef, chicken, eggs. *Note: Wild-caught sardines are often cheaper, more sustainable, and pack a denser nutritional punch than farmed salmon.*
- **Non-starchy vegetables (1/2 of your plate):** Leafy greens, broccoli, cauliflower, peppers, courgettes.
- **Smart carbohydrates (1/4 of your plate):** Sweet potatoes, quinoa, oats, in modest portions.
- **Healthy fats:** Extra-virgin olive oil, avocado, nuts, and seeds.

UK Supermarket Shopping List



Proteins

- **Meat, Poultry & Fish:** Chicken breasts, lean beef mince, wild-caught tinned sardines (in spring water or olive oil), salmon fillets, cod, eggs.
- **Dairy & Alternatives:** Greek yoghurt (plain, full-fat), cottage cheese.

Non-Starchy Vegetables

- **Leafy Greens:** Spinach, kale, broccoli, cauliflower, Brussels sprouts.
- **Other Veg:** Courgettes, bell peppers, mushrooms, green beans, tomatoes.

Smart Carbohydrates

- **Whole Grains:** Porridge oats, quinoa, brown rice.
- **Starchy Veg & Fruit:** Sweet potatoes, berries, apples.

Healthy Fats

- **Oils & Nuts:** Extra virgin olive oil, coconut oil, butter/ghee, almonds, walnuts, chia seeds, flaxseeds, avocados.

Foods to Eliminate

- **Industrial Seed Oils:** Rapeseed/canola, sunflower, soybean, corn, cottonseed, generic "vegetable oil".
- **Refined Sugars:** Sweets, biscuits, cakes, sugary fizzy drinks.
- **Ultra-Processed Foods:** Ready meals, processed snacks, fast food.
- **Excessive Caffeine & Alcohol:** Can disrupt sleep and worsen hot flushes.

Multi-Ethnic UK Meal Ideas

Keep meals high-protein, high-veg, low-junk, with culturally familiar staples in modest portions.

African / Afro-Caribbean

Meal	Example
Breakfast	Eggs with spinach and a small portion of boiled plantain, cooked in coconut oil
Lunch	Grilled chicken with a large mixed salad and a small portion of jollof rice (cooked in olive oil, not seed oil)
Dinner	Fish stew (using tinned sardines or fresh mackerel) with leafy greens and a small piece of yam

South Asian

Meal	Example
Breakfast	Masala omelette with tomatoes, onions, and fresh coriander, cooked in ghee
Lunch	Chicken tikka with a large portion of cucumber/tomato raita and half a chapati
Dinner	Lamb keema with spinach (saag) and cauliflower rice

Western / British

Meal	Example
Breakfast	Greek yoghurt with berries, chia seeds, and a handful of almonds
Lunch	Wild-caught sardines on a small slice of sourdough with a large side salad dressed in olive oil
Dinner	Roast chicken breast with broccoli, carrots, and a small portion of roasted sweet potato

Plant-Forward

Meal	Example
Breakfast	Tofu scramble with spinach and mushrooms, cooked in coconut oil
Lunch	Lentil and vegetable soup with a side salad
Dinner	Chickpea curry with cauliflower rice and a small portion of quinoa

Part 5 – Movement: Strength, Steps, and Sanity

Movement in perimenopause is not about burning calories or punishing your body. It is about preserving muscle, protecting bones, improving insulin sensitivity, and buffering your nervous system against adrenaline spikes.

Tier	Daily Movement	Strength Training	Best for
Tier 1	10-minute daily walk	1 bodyweight session (15 mins)	Beginners / low energy weeks
Tier 2	20-minute daily walk	2 strength sessions (30 mins)	Building momentum
Tier 3	8,000+ daily steps	3 strength sessions (40 mins)	Full programme

Key exercises for perimenopause: Squats, lunges, glute bridges, press-ups (or wall press-ups), dumbbell rows, and plank holds. These target the large muscle groups that matter most for metabolic health and bone density.

Part 6 – Sleep & Nervous System Reset



The Non-Negotiables

- **Consistent Wake Time:** Wake up at the same time every day, including weekends. This is the single most powerful action for sleep in perimenopause.
- **Morning Sunlight:** Get outside within 30 minutes of waking. Melatonin (your sleep hormone) is produced in the morning through sunlight exposure, but released at night.
- **Wind-Down Routine:** Dim lights 1–2 hours before bed, avoid screens for the last 30 minutes.
- **Cool Bedroom:** 16–18°C is ideal for perimenopause-related night waking.

If You Wake Between 2am and 4am

This is extremely common in perimenopause and is often driven by a progesterone dip or an adrenaline surge. Do not lie in bed staring at the ceiling. Get up, go to a different room, do something quiet for 10–15 minutes in dim light (reading, gentle stretching), then return to bed. Do not look at your phone.

Part 7 – Managing Specific Symptoms & Supplements

1. Hot Flushes & Night Sweats

- **Identify Triggers:** Alcohol, caffeine, spicy foods, high-sugar meals, and stress are common triggers.
- **Keep Cool:** Layer clothing and use breathable, natural fabrics (cotton, linen, bamboo) for sleepwear and bedding.
- **Address the root:** Hot flushes are driven by adrenaline spikes. The Morning Reset, grounding, and reduced caffeine/alcohol all help lower your baseline sympathetic tone.

2. Vaginal Dryness & Libido

- **Nutrition for Lubrication:** Omega-3 fatty acids (found in wild-caught sardines, salmon, and walnuts) support healthy blood flow and tissue hydration.
- **Local Treatments:** Do not suffer in silence. Over-the-counter vaginal moisturisers (used regularly) and lubricants (used during intimacy) are highly effective. If these are insufficient, speak to your GP about localised vaginal oestrogen, which is safe for most women and highly effective.

3. Grounding (Earthing) – A Bonus Tool

- **What it is:** Walking barefoot on natural surfaces like grass, soil, or sand.
- **Why it may help:** Emerging evidence suggests that connecting with the earth's natural electrical charge can help reduce inflammation, lower cortisol (stress hormone) levels, and improve sleep quality. Try spending 10 minutes barefoot in your garden during your morning sunlight exposure.

Supplements: Optional and GP-Aware

Supplement	Why it may help	Notes
Vitamin D	Essential for bone health, mood, and immune function	Most UK adults are deficient in winter. Consider 1000–2000 IU daily. [26]

Supplement	Why it may help	Notes
Omega-3	Supports heart and brain health, reduces inflammation	From oily fish or a quality fish oil supplement. [27]
Magnesium	Can help with sleep, anxiety, and muscle cramps	Magnesium glycinate or citrate before bed. [28]
Creatine	Supports muscle strength and cognitive function	3–5g daily. Emerging evidence for brain health in women. [29]

Part 8 – Tracking & FAQs

Weekly Tracking Checklist

Metric	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Sleep Quality (1–10)							
Energy Levels (1–10)							
Mood (1–10)							
Protein Goal Met?							
Movement Done?							
Morning Reset Done?							

General FAQs

What if I miss a whole week?

Do not panic. Restart from Week 1, focusing on the 10-Minute Morning Reset, a fixed wake time, and one protein meal per day. That is your bare minimum reset.

What if my hot flushes get worse before they get better?

This can happen as your body adjusts, particularly if you are reducing caffeine and alcohol (which were masking underlying adrenaline patterns). Focus on grounding, slow breathing, and reducing triggers. If flushes are severe and unmanageable, speak to your GP.

What if I am already on HRT?

This plan complements HRT beautifully. HRT provides the hormones, but this plan builds the

metabolic and nervous system foundation that makes HRT work better. Continue your HRT as prescribed.

What if my GP says my blood tests are fine but I still feel awful?

"Normal" blood tests do not invalidate your symptoms. Standard NHS ranges are very broad. Focus on the lifestyle interventions in this guide, and consider a specialist review if symptoms persist.

Can I do this plan if I work shifts?

Yes. Adjust your TRE window to fit your shifts. Prioritise the 10-Minute Morning Reset (sunlight) whenever you wake up — even if that is 2pm — to anchor your circadian rhythm. Fixed wake time is relative to your shift pattern.

What if my hot flushes get worse before they get better?

This can happen as your body adjusts. Focus on grounding, slow breathing, and reducing adrenaline triggers like caffeine and alcohol. If they remain severe after 2–3 weeks, book a GP review.

Part 9 – Stress, Cortisol, and Nervous System Regulation

Chronic stress and elevated cortisol levels are major drivers of perimenopausal symptoms. When cortisol is chronically high, it can disrupt sleep, increase belly fat, worsen hot flushes, and exacerbate anxiety. Many women in their 40s are running on adrenaline without realising it — the "wired but tired" feeling is a hallmark of sympathetic overdrive.

Key Strategies for Nervous System Regulation

The 10-Minute Morning Reset

As introduced in Part 2, morning sunlight and grounding are powerful tools for setting a healthy cortisol rhythm. Cortisol should peak in the morning and decline through the day. Morning light helps calibrate this pattern.

Breathwork

Simple practices can quickly down-shift your nervous system from a sympathetic (fight-or-flight) state to a parasympathetic (rest-and-digest) state:

- **Box breathing:** Inhale for 4 seconds, hold for 4, exhale for 4, hold for 4. Repeat 4–6 cycles.
- **Extended exhale:** Inhale for 4 seconds, exhale for 6–8 seconds. The longer exhale activates the vagus nerve.
- **Physiological sigh:** Two quick inhales through the nose, followed by one long exhale through the mouth. Instantly calming.

Boundaries

Learn to say no. Protecting your time and energy is a crucial part of managing stress during perimenopause. Many women in their 40s are carrying the mental load of family, work, ageing parents, and their own health changes simultaneously. You cannot pour from an empty cup.

Grounding Practice

Standing or walking barefoot on grass, soil, or sand for 10–20 minutes has emerging evidence for reducing cortisol and improving sleep. Combine this with your Morning Reset for maximum benefit.

Part 10 – Glossary

Circadian rhythm: Your body's internal 24-hour clock that regulates sleep, wakefulness, and hormone production. It is set primarily by morning light exposure.

HPA axis: The hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal axis — a complex system that controls your body's response to stress. When chronically activated, it can drive fatigue, weight gain, and hormonal imbalance.

Sympathetic nervous system: The part of your nervous system that triggers the "fight or flight" response, releasing adrenaline and cortisol. Overactivation drives hot flushes, palpitations, and anxiety.

Adrenaline (epinephrine): A stress hormone that increases heart rate and blood pressure. It often spikes during hot flushes and "rage episodes" in perimenopause.

DHEA and DHEA-S: Precursor hormones produced by the adrenal glands that can be converted into oestrogen and testosterone. Levels decline with age and are measured via blood test.

Pregnenolone: A precursor hormone that is the starting point for the production of many other hormones, including progesterone, DHEA, and cortisol. Sometimes called the "mother hormone".

Insulin resistance / insulin sensitivity: How well your cells respond to insulin. Resistance means your body struggles to process sugar efficiently, leading to weight gain (especially around the middle), fatigue, and increased disease risk.

TRE (time-restricted eating): Eating all your meals within a specific window of time each day (e.g. 10–12 hours), allowing your body to rest and repair overnight during the fasting period.

Progesterone vs oestrogen: The two main female sex hormones. Oestrogen is stimulating and supports brain function, bone health, and skin elasticity. Progesterone is calming and supports sleep, mood stability, and pregnancy. Both fluctuate and decline during perimenopause.

Seed oils: Highly processed industrial oils (like sunflower, canola/rapeseed, and soybean oil) that are often high in inflammatory omega-6 fatty acids. Found in most processed foods and restaurant cooking.

Grounding / earthing: The practice of making direct physical contact with the earth (e.g., walking barefoot on grass or soil) to reduce stress and inflammation. Emerging evidence supports benefits for sleep and cortisol levels.

Metabolic syndrome: A cluster of conditions (high blood pressure, high blood sugar, excess body fat around the waist, abnormal cholesterol) that increase the risk of heart disease and type 2 diabetes. Risk increases during perimenopause.

Part 11 – References & Further Reading

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